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Dark stretches leave PU women wary of late-night walks

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Chandigarh: The AC Joshi Library at Panjab University (PU) remains accessible to students round the clock, but for many women, the journey back to their hostels after late-night study sessions is nerve-wracking.

Dark stretches along internal roads, particularly on routes connecting the library area to girls' hostels, have emerged as a persistent concern, with students saying they are uncomfortable walking alone through poorly illuminated patches after sunset.

The issue has gained renewed significance amid growing complaints of harassment involving people travelling in vehicles, a recent incident in Sector 15 and student organisations' demand for a complete ban on four-wheelers on campus.

The concern centres on specific stretches where inadequate lighting creates dark spots along otherwise frequently used campus roads. One such route connects the area near Boys' Hostel No. 3 to Girls' Hostels 1 and 2, while another passes between the university ground and tennis court towards Girls' Hostels 3, 4 and 5. Students using the library late into the night have to cross these stretches while returning to their residential accommodation.

The problem is particularly concerning for women who leave the library after late-night study sessions. While the

university provides access to academic facilities throughout the night, students say the roads connecting these facilities to hostels also need to be adequately illuminated to ensure safe movement.

The issue had been highlighted earlier as well, with students pointing to non-functional streetlights and inadequate CCTV coverage along these routes. The university had proposed a third phase of CCTV installation, with an estimated budget of Rs 75 lakh, covering 10 additional locations, including the stretches leading towards girls' hostels.

PU Campus Students' Council president Ankit Bidhan said he had taken up the issue of faulty streetlights with the university's electrical department.

"I have already asked the electrical department to get the streetlights repaired. They have been asked to rectify the problem within the next few days," Bidhan said.

The concerns over dark spots have coincided with a renewed debate over vehicular movement on campus. On Oct 30, student organisations staged a demonstration outside the vice-chancellor's office, demanding a complete ban on four-wheelers inside the university.

The protesters alleged that several harassment incidents involved people travelling in cars, who allegedly followed women students, passed comments and targeted them during 'geri' rounds.

Students argued that unrestricted vehicular movement made it difficult to identify and monitor those responsible for such incidents. They also recalled the 2015 fatal accident in which a car driver ran over a girl student on campus. The incident had led to a student referendum on restricting vehicular movement, and the latest protest has revived the demand.

The issue has also acquired a wider dimension following the recent harassment incident near Sector 15 market, where a PU student allegedly confronted two men travelling in a Mahindra Thar. A video of the confrontation

went viral on social media, bringing renewed attention to the safety concerns of women students in areas frequented by them outside the university.

Demand for vehicle-free campus

At a discussion organised under the banner of ‘Half the Sky’ on Oct 27, more than 50 students, including boys and girls, shared their experiences of harassment and restrictions on their everyday movement

Participants spoke about being followed by men in vehicles, unwanted attention during ‘geri’ rounds and precautions women take while travelling alone

The students demanded a vehicle-free campus, reforms in the university’s Internal Complaints Committee and free university transport round the clock

The demands also underline the need for a comprehensive approach to campus safety.